Saraswati is ubiquitous, widely honoured and portrayed, and there is a specific day devoted each year to her exaltation, Saraswati Puja, whereas there is none to Brahma. That she is merely a consort to one of the holy trinity is irrelevant to her importance. Hinduism cannot entirely be absolved of gender bias, but its reverence for the female principle in the godhead is exemplary.

No better example of this exists than the many manifestations of the goddess in the form of Shakti, which literally means strength—the power of the life-force that creates, nurtures, sustains and also destroys the world. The goddess is seen as a source of energy, without which the male aspect of the godhead would be ineffectual. This female energy takes many forms. As Saraswati, she embodies learning; as Lakshmi, wealth and prosperity. As Uma or Parvati, she is Shiva's gentle *ardhangani*, his half, as inseparable from the Lord as fire and heat, or *purusha* (the spirit) and *prakriti* (matter), are inseparable. As Kamakshi or Rajarajeshwari, she is the Great Mother. As Durga, she rides a tiger, bearing weapons to fight the eight evils of humankind—greed, hate, envy, contempt for others, passion, vanity, jealousy and illusion. In her most frightening form she is Kali, the personification of time (*kala*), dark, angry and armed, weapons flailing, her body dripping with blood, wearing the skulls of her victims, sometimes holding aloft the severed head of one or grinding her foot into the prone body of another.

If that sounds macabre, there are fifty-one Shakti-peethas (temples to the goddess) across India, each consecrated to a body part of Shiva's first wife, Sati, whose body was said to have been dismembered in fifty-one pieces by the flying Sudarshana Chakra weapon of Lord Vishnu. (Sati had killed herself during a fire sacrifice conducted by her father, and her disconsolate husband was carrying her body around in grief and mourning; Vishnu's act was intended to get Shiva to snap out of it. Sati was duly reincarnated as Parvati.) There are temples where the goddess retreats into seclusion for three days a month to menstruate, as in Chengannur in Kerala; others where Devi's footprint (on stone) alone is worshipped. My home state of Kerala overflows with temples to the goddess, often referred to simply as Devi or Bhagavathi (both of which simply mean the goddess), though the most popular form of Bhagavathi-